

FIRST SPARRINGS READINESS MANUAL

A progress-first plan for your first sessions.

WHY I WROTE THIS







Sparring is the highest volume head impact activity most boxers do, and it happens in training, not competition. I have trained boxing competitively for over six years and trained in recreational and competitive gyms in more than five countries. The patterns below show up regardless of culture.

> **JOURNAL OF SCIENCE AND MEDICINE IN SPORT, 2026**
>
> Measured with head impact sensors, competitive boxers take between 2 and 8 impacts to the head per minute during sparring. Peak linear acceleration runs 14 to 30g, similar to the force of other full contact sports.

This is educational material written by a coach. It is not medical advice.

Boxing carries a risk of head injury, and sparring carries that risk every session.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

01 WHAT FIRST SPARRING REALLY IS

02 GYM, COACH AND PARTNERS

03 THE SPARRING ACTION

04 POST-SPARRING

05 FINAL THOUGHTS

01

WHAT FIRST SPARRING REALLY IS

The point of your first sparrings is to apply basics, test your timing, and test your composure. It is not a test of whether you are tough.

Bruce Lee called sparring "the laboratory" of martial arts, the place where you discover whether your ideas work against someone who is trying to hit you. Sparring inevitably brings out adrenaline, flaws, and habits you did not see before.

NORMALISE THE FEAR

Fear and adrenaline are part of the learning, the same way failing a lift is part of getting strong.

In your first sessions, you are training the ability to think while adrenaline is running.

SELF-ASSESSMENT CHECKLIST

1. At least three months of basic training done.

This gets you throwing basic straight punches with okay form, controlled partner drills, cardio for two to three light rounds, and some understanding of your own emotional state under pressure.

For contrast, England Boxing's 2026 rule book requires a minimum of thirty days of safe sparring before a first bout.

2. Equipment.

- Gloves. Up to 141 lbs (64kg), use 14oz. Above 141 lbs, use 16oz. Ideally both partners are in the same weight category and glove weight.
- Mouthguard, hand wraps, headgear.
- Groin protector. Once you spar regularly, this is essential kit.

IF ANY OF THESE ARE MISSING

Stay in drills and controlled work. You do not yet know your strengths and weaknesses, the different levels of power, or how to defend and avoid power punches.

02

GYM, COACH AND PARTNERS

This is not always visible in every gym. A gym that will not honour a request to slow down or break training down will not honour anything else either.

WHAT A COACH SHOULD BE DOING

In general, a coach should:

- Explain what you are working on that training day.
- Check that everyone is in correct ounce gloves with a mouthguard in.
- Watch the rounds and correct people when they go too far.
- Time the rounds, out loud.
- Pair new people with partners who can control themselves.

GREEN FLAGS

- A coach is present for every round.
- There is a stated rule for what happens after someone takes a heavy shot.
- Beginners are put through limited sparring first, not open sparring.
- People are told to slow down, and they slow down.

RED FLAGS

- Anyone tells you getting hit is just how you learn.
- Beginners are put into open sparring on their first day.
- Nobody checks gloves.
- The biggest or most experienced person in the gym is used to test newcomers.

QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE YOUR FIRST SESSION

1. How do you introduce beginners to sparring here?
2. How do you prevent participants from getting hurt?

You are looking for whether there is an answer at all, more than what the answer is.

SCRIPTS FOR YOUR PARTNER

- *"Let's do a theme. Jab only, or body shots only, this round."*
- *"Let's do 30 to 40 percent so I can work on defence."*
- *"Can you throw more of one punch, right hands for example, so I can work on that defence?"*

When it is escalating and you need it to stop, say between rounds, without an apology attached: *"Let's bring it down."*

If it does not come down after that, do not negotiate a second time. Switch partners.

SCRIPTS FOR YOUR COACH

Give the coach one target per round.

- *"Tell me what I do right after I get hit."*
- *"Tell me if I am holding my breath."*
- *"Tell me if I am moving straight back."*

This prevents disadvantaged positions like being exhausted, stuck in a corner, or taking too many punches unnecessarily. Then ask for one correction.

Ideally, you have done your homework and have a task for each round. In that case your partner and your coach do not have to know anything. They can add to it or make adjustments.

THE MINDSET

You will feel sore and fatigued. Everything else is what you make of it.

Relaxation improves performance and cognitive function, but do not aim for calm in your first sparring.

PRE-SPARRING ROUTINE

2 MINUTES

Slow breathing.

Nasal inhale for four seconds, exhale for six seconds. Slow diaphragmatic breathing supports relaxation and becomes automatic over time.

2 MINUTES

Shake out.

Shake out, then shadowbox at the intensity you are about to spar at. If the round is 30 percent, shadowbox at 30 percent to prime your nervous system.

2 MINUTES

Imagery.

Mental practice has an effect alongside physical practice. Start by visualizing a stable stance, throwing the first jab, breathing, and resetting into your stance.

Beginners usually only visualize landing the perfect punch or counter, but exchanges bring no rehearsal or response plan, so visualize complicated and awkward situations too.

30 SECONDS

Quick pre-round check.

Name one task for this round.

03

THE SPARRING ACTION

Constrained sparring builds up skill levels. It can feel limiting, but it isolates movements and patterns so you can improve measurably.

Each progression builds a certain skill, and it also has gaps. It is important to understand what gap each progression exposes. Hooks only, for example, keeps your center lane open.

#	STAGE	BENEFIT	GAP
1	Movement only	Distance, ring positioning	Nothing coming back
2	Jabbing at shoulders	Range finding with a live target	Minimum guard and defence involved
3	Straight punches at shoulders	Straight line accuracy, technique	Minimum guard and defence involved
4	Lead hand only (jab, hook, uppercut)	Outside control, lead hand as a measuring tool	Unattacked side gets exposed
5	Rear hand only	Timing the cross, defending the cross	Unattacked side gets exposed
6	Body only	Level change, body defence, close range	Head stays exposed
7	Hooks only	Side angles, close range defence	Center lane exposed
8	Light open, 30 to 40 percent	Everything at once, decision making	Lower intensity, less risk involved

HOW YOU KNOW YOU CAN ADVANCE

- You can see setups and punches coming before they land.
- You are aware of your breath throughout the round, instead of holding it on specific parts.
- You are sticking to the task in round three, and not getting caught up.

VOLUME IN THE EARLY SESSIONS

Two to three rounds is a solid session. There is no established safe threshold for repetitive head impacts, so get the learning with the fewest impacts you can. Fewer, more controlled rounds beat more, harder rounds every time.

SIMPLE RULES

- Eyes on the chest, or eye contact. Do not watch the hands.
- Exhale with each movement and sequence, defensive and offensive.
- Offense and defense in every round.
- Be aware of your hand positioning and how it affects your boxing, especially when you are tired or right after you land something.
- Keep footwork basic and use it to set up angles.

THE THREE THINGS ADRENALINE WILL DO TO YOU

1. Holding your breath. Fix: exhale on every punch, defense, and movement.

2. Closing your eyes or turning your head away. Fix: keep eyes on the chest at close range.

3. Trying to punch back immediately after getting hit. Fix: get your stance balanced first. Attack after, or change position.

WHAT NOT TO FOCUS ON

- Winning the round.
- Looking good.
- Landing the one combination you have been practicing on the bag.

04

POST-SPARRING

Repeated, controlled exposure makes fear and panic fade.

TALK TO YOUR PARTNER

If they had a highlight moment:

- *"What did you see when you threw that punch?"*
- *"Why did you throw it there?"*
- *"Which part of the round gave you the most trouble?"*

Ask about their experience to understand what works.

TALK TO YOUR COACH

"What were my best and worst moments?" Ask for the contrast.

RECORD IT

It is always easiest to make comments from the side. Setting your phone down to record makes a real difference in seeing what you could not have from the first person point of view.

TAKE NOTES AFTER

Memory performance measurably drops after sparring and returns to baseline about 24 hours later. Talk with your training partners or take notes after, then review the footage later. Find a pattern to work on next time.

ADAPTATION

Repeated, controlled exposure makes fear and panic fade.

WHEN TO SWITCH PARTNERS

Every round, or every couple of rounds. Everybody has a different style and different timing.

WHEN TO SWITCH GYMS

- People tell you that getting hit is normal.
- Nobody supports your initiative to improve or get clarity.
- Requests to lower intensity get ignored or mocked.
- No one is watching the sparring.

WHEN TO STOP

SEEK EMERGENCY CARE IMMEDIATELY IF

- Worsening or severe headache
- Repeated vomiting
- Seizure or convulsion
- Double vision or loss of vision
- Weakness or tingling in the arms or legs
- Neck pain
- Loss of consciousness

VISIBLE SIGNS SOMEONE ELSE SHOULD BE WATCHING FOR

- Slow to get up after a shot.
- Blank or vacant look.
- Disorientation, confusion, staring, unable to answer questions properly.
- Unsteady on the feet, poor coordination.

Return to boxing after a suspected concussion only when it is staged and medically guided.

05

FINAL THOUGHTS

Choose the right people and follow progressions that match your current skill level.

If this helped your sparring sessions and you want a full step-by-step structure for footwork, defense and sparring progression, that's what TRB Grade is for.

TRB GRADE →

THEERAINERS.COM/COACHING